The physiological mechanisms in relation to flowering are controlled by (i) light period (Photoperiodism) and (ii) temperature (Vernalization). The physiological change on flowering due to relative length of light and darkness (photoperiod) is called **Photoperiodism**. The term photoperiodism was coined by **Garner** and **Allard** (1920) when they observed this in 'Biloxi' variety of soybean (*Glycine max*) and 'Maryland mammoth' variety of tobacco (*Nicotiana tabacum*). The photoperiod required to induce flowering is called **critical day length**. Maryland mammoth (tobacco variety) requires 12 hours of light and cocklebur (*Xanthium pensylvanicum*) requires 15.05 hours of light for flowering.

1. Classification of plants based on Photoperiodism

i. **Long day plants**: The plants that require long critical day length for flowering are called long day plants or short night plants. Example: Pea, Barley and Oats.

ii. **Short day plants**: The plants that require a short critical day length for flowering are called short day plants or long night plants. Example: Tobacco, Cocklebur, Soybean, Rice and *Chrysanthemum*.

iii. **Day neutral plants**: There are a number of plants which can flower in all possible photoperiods. They are also called **photo neutrals** or **indeterminate plants**. Example: Potato, *Rhododendron*, Tomato and Cotton.

2. Photoperiodic induction

An appropriate photoperiod in 24 hours' cycle constitutes one inductive cycle. Plants may require one or more inductive cycles for flowering. The phenomenon of conversion of leaf primordia into flower primordia under the influence of suitable inductive cycles is called **photoperiodic induction**. Example: *Xanthium* (SDP) – 1 inductive cycle and *Plantago* (LDP) – 25 inductive cycles.

3. Site of Photoinductive perception

Photoperiodic stimulus is perceived by the leaves. Floral hormone is synthesised in leaves and translocated to the apical tip to promote flowering. This can be explained by a simple experiment on Cocklebur (*Xanthium pensylvanicum*), a short day plant. Usually *Xanthium* will flower under short day conditions. If the plant is defoliated and kept under short day conditions it will not flower. Flowering will occur even when all the leaves are removed except one leaf. If a cocklebur plant is defoliated and kept under long day conditions, it will not flower. If one of its leaves is exposed to short day condition and rest are in long day condition, flowering will occur (Figure 15.10).

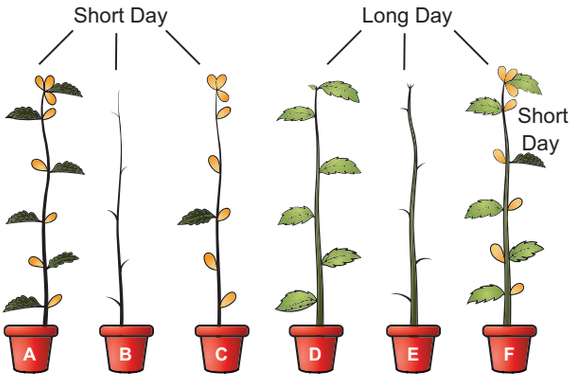
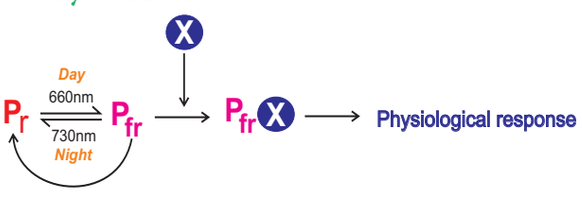


Figure 15.10: Experiment on Cocklebur plant showing photoperiodic stimulus

4. Importance of photoperiodism

1. The knowledge of photoperiodism plays an important role in hybridisation experiments.
2. Photoperiodism is an excellent example of physiological pre-conditioning that is using an external factor to induce physiological changes in the plant.

5. Phytochrome



Phytochrome is a bluish biliprotein pigment responsible for the perception of light in photo physiological process. **Butler *et al.*,**

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